

# **The Exorcism of Emily Rose**

## **Part I: The Body / The Case Opens**

### **THE EXORCISM OF EMILY ROSE**

#### **PROLOGUE: THE BARN**

The cold in November didn't just sit on the skin; it burrowed. It found the gaps in your coat, the seams in your boots, the hollow spaces in your chest. It was a living thing, a predator that had been waiting for the sun to go down so it could feed.

Maria Rose stood on the back porch of the farmhouse, her hands wrapped around a ceramic mug that had gone lukewarm ten minutes ago. It was a novelty mug, something Emily had bought her at the state fair years ago. It said \*World's Okayest Mom\* in faded blue letters. Maria traced the letters with a thumb that was cracked and stained with garden soil. She wasn't drinking the coffee. She was just holding it, using the ceramic as a failing anchor against the wind.

The wind was screaming.

It came off the plains, tearing through the dead cornstalks, rattling the windows in their frames. It sounded like a thousand people whispering all at once, or maybe one person screaming from a very long way away. \*Hssssssss.\* It was the sound of the earth trying to scrape the house off its back.

Maria looked out at the barn.

It sat on the hill, a dark, hulking shape against the grey sky. The wood was black with rain and age. The roof was tin, rusted in patches that looked like dried blood. In the summer, the roof sang when the storms came, a chaotic drumroll of hail and rain.

Tonight, it was silent.

Too silent.

"Maria?"

She turned. Her husband, Nathaniel, was standing in the doorway. He looked older than he had a week ago. Ten years older. His face was grey, the lines around his mouth etched deep with a chisel of exhaustion. He was wearing his heavy Carhartt work coat, the canvas stained with oil and... something else.

Something dark and crusted on the sleeve.

Blood? Or just mud?

Maria didn't ask. She didn't want to know.

"Is it over?" Maria asked. Her voice was small, a ghost of a sound that was snatched away by the wind before it even reached him.

Nathaniel didn't answer immediately. He looked past her, towards the barn. His eyes were red-rimmed, sunken into dark hollows. He looked like a man who had seen the end of the world and was trying to figure out how to explain it.

"The car is coming," he said finally. His voice was gravel. "The doctor."

Maria felt a shiver that had nothing to do with the wind. It started at the base of her spine and wrapped around her ribs like a cold wire.

"The doctor? But Father Moore said..."

"Father Moore is praying," Nathaniel said. He stepped out onto the porch, the boards creaking under his weight. \*Creak. Groan.\* The house was settling, shifting in the cold. He smelled of wet hay, diesel fuel, and ozone. That sharp, electrical smell that comes after a lightning strike.

"He's been praying for an hour, Maria. But she isn't moving."

Maria dropped the mug.

It hit the wooden planks and shattered. Brown liquid splashed against her boots, steaming in the cold air. The shards of ceramic skittered across the porch like frightened beetles. \*World's Okayest Mom\* lay in fragments.

She didn't look down.

She ran.

She ran off the porch and into the mud. The yard was a quagmire, the frozen earth turning to slush under the relentless sleet. The mud sucked at her boots, trying to hold her back, trying to keep her from the truth. \*Squelch. Squelch.\*

The wind slapped her face, stinging her eyes, freezing the tears before they could fall.

She didn't feel the cold. She didn't feel her legs. She only felt the pull of the barn.

The barn door was open a crack. A sliver of darkness against the grey night.

Maria pushed it open. The hinges screamed, a sound of rusted metal grinding against rusted metal.

The smell hit her first.

It wasn't the smell of animals. It wasn't the smell of hay or manure or old wood.

It was the smell of a battery that had burst. Acrid. Metallic. Copper and sulfur.

And underneath that, something sweet. Cloying.

Rotting lilies.

It was the smell of a funeral home that had been left in the sun.

"Emily?" she whispered.

The inside of the barn was shadowed, lit only by a single kerosene lantern hanging from a beam. The light swung back and forth in the draft, casting long, dancing shadows on the walls. The shadows stretched and warped, looking like clawed hands reaching for the ceiling.

Father Moore was kneeling by the cot in the center of the threshing floor.

He looked small.

His black cassock was ruined, torn at the shoulder, stained with mud and white residue—salt? Holy water?

His head was bowed. His hands were clasped so tightly the knuckles were white, the skin stretched to the breaking point.

He was muttering. A low, constant stream of Latin.

\*"...requiem aeternam dona ei, Domine... et lux perpetua luceat ei..."\*

Maria stopped. Her breath caught in her throat, a jagged lump of ice.

Emily was lying on the cot.

She looked... small.

So small. Like a bird that had flown into a window and broken its neck.

Her body was covered by a thin grey blanket, but Maria could see the outline of her form. The sharp jut of her hip bones. The cage of her ribs.

She weighed nothing. Less than nothing.

Her arms were at her sides. Her legs were straight. The restraints—the heavy leather straps they had been forced to use, God forgive them—were loose now. They lay on the floor like dead snakes.

Her eyes were open.

They were staring up at the rafters.

But they weren't seeing the wood. They weren't seeing the lantern. They weren't seeing the dust motes dancing in the light.

They were seeing something else. Something far away.

And they were still.

So terribly, perfectly still.

The whites of her eyes were red, hemorrhaged from the strain of the screaming. But the pupils... the pupils were dilated, black pools that seemed to go on forever.

"No," Maria whispered.

Father Moore stopped praying. He didn't turn around. His shoulders slumped, as if the strings holding him up had been cut.

"I'm sorry, Maria," he said. His voice was a ruin. A broken thing. "We... we lost her."

Maria walked to the cot. Her legs felt like wood. She fell to her knees in the straw. The straw poked through her jeans, sharp and unforgiving.

She reached out and touched Emily's hand.

It was cold.

Not just winter cold.

Stone cold. The cold of marble. The cold of something that had never been warm.

"Emily," Maria said. She brushed a strand of hair from her daughter's forehead. The hair was matted with sweat and dirt. The skin beneath was bruised, purple and yellow, a map of the war that had been fought in this room.

"Emily, baby. Wake up. It's Mama."

Emily didn't move. She didn't blink. She didn't breathe.

But on her face...

Maria leaned closer, her tears finally falling, hot tracks on her frozen cheeks.

There was something there.

Not fear.

Not pain.

Not the twisted rictus of the Demon that had worn her face for so long.

It was a smile.

A faint, ghost of a smile. Peaceful. Serene.

As if, in the final moment, the horror had broken, and she had seen something beautiful. Something that made all the pain worth it.

Then the sirens started.

Wailing in the distance, getting louder. \*Whoop-whoop. Whoop-whoop.\*

The world was coming. The police. The coroner. The questions. The accusations.

The Barn door banged open in the wind.

Snow began to drift in, settling on Emily's still face like a shroud.

Maria Rose closed her eyes and screamed.

But the wind took the sound and carried it away, leaving only the silence of the barn.

And the smell of sulfur, slowly fading into the cold.

## **PART I: THE BODY / THE CASE OPENS**

### **CHAPTER 1: 3:00**

The digital clock on the nightstand didn't tick. It just burned.

Red numbers in the dark.

\*2:59.\*

Erin Bruner watched it. She didn't want to. She wanted to be asleep. She *\*needed\** to be asleep. Tomorrow was the Van Hopper verdict, and she needed to be sharp. She needed to be the "Iron Lady" the press loved to hate. The "Giant Killer."

But her body wouldn't cooperate. Her muscles were tight, coiled like springs under the Egyptian cotton sheets. Her mind was a hamster wheel of closing arguments and "what-ifs," spinning faster and faster.

\*Did I emphasize the timeline enough? Did Juror 4 buy the doubt? Did Van Hopper look sad enough? Did I smile too much? Did I smile too little?\*

She rolled over, pulling the duvet up to her chin. The condo was silent. Thirty floors up, the city noise was just a hum, a vibration in the floorboards.

She hated this condo. She bought it because it was what a Senior Partner was supposed to have. Floor-to-ceiling glass. Minimalist furniture. "Clean lines."

But "clean lines" meant no place to hide.

At night, the city lights reflected off the glass, turning the room into a kaleidoscope of orange and neon blue. It felt like sleeping in a fishbowl.

She closed her eyes.

\*Relax. Breathe. In for four, hold for four, out for four.\*

It was a technique her therapist had taught her. Dr. Evans. A nice woman with a soft voice and a diploma from Yale.

Erin had fired her three months ago.

\*Why?\*

Because Dr. Evans had suggested that Erin chose law because she liked \*controlling the narrative\*. That she defended criminals because it gave her power over chaos.

\*I don't need power,\* Erin had told her, writing the final check. \*I need to win.\*

Winning wasn't power. Winning was survival.

She opened her eyes.

The clock changed.

\*3:00.\*

Erin exhaled. Okay. Three a.m. The witching hour. The hour of the wolf. The hour where lonely people realized just how big their beds were.

She reached for the glass of water on the nightstand. It was a crystal tumbler, heavy and expensive.

Her hand froze.

The air in the room had changed.

It wasn't a draft. A draft was movement. A draft was physics.

This was... heavy. Static.

Like the air before a thunderstorm, when the ions charge the atmosphere and the hair on your arms stands up.

But the sky outside was clear. She could see the moon, a cold white coin hanging over the lake.

And the smell.

Erin sniffed.

It was faint, but distinct.

Something burning?

Toast?

No. Not toast. Toast was organic. This smelled chemical.

It smelled like... old pennies. Copper. Blood.

And something underneath it. Something sweet and cloying. Like flowers left in a vase too long, until the water turns grey and slimy.

It was the smell of decay.

"Jasper?" she whispered.

Her Persian cat usually slept at the foot of the bed, a heavy, purring anchor. A warm weight that reminded her she wasn't completely alone.

Tonight, the bed was light.

Erin sat up. "Jasper?"

She looked towards the bedroom door. It was ajar.

A shadow moved in the hallway.

Just a shift in the darkness. A deepening of the black.

Erin's heart did a double-tap against her ribs.

\*Intruder.\*

The word was a splash of ice water.

She slid out of bed, her bare feet sinking into the carpet. She grabbed the heavy brass lamp from the table. It was a ludicrous weapon—a piece of "modern art" that looked like a twisted spine—but it was solid. It would break a skull.

She crept to the door.

"I have a gun!" she lied. Her voice sounded thin, reedy. Not the voice of the Iron Lady.

Silence.

She stepped into the hallway.

It was empty.

The living room beyond was bathed in the orange glow of the streetlights filtering through the floor-to-ceiling windows.

"Jasper?"

She found him.

He was standing on the back of the sofa, silhouetted against the city lights.

His back was arched. His fur was standing straight up, making him look twice his size.

He was hissing.

A low, guttural sound that vibrated in the room. It wasn't the sound of a cat annoyed by a toy. It was the sound of a predator facing a threat.

He wasn't looking at Erin.

He was looking at the corner. At the Eames lounge chair Erin's father had given her as a graduation present.

Erin looked at the chair.

It was empty.

The leather was distressed, worn soft by years of reading briefs and drinking wine.

But as she watched, the seat cushion... moved.

It depressed.

Slowly. Inch by inch.

As if a heavy weight was settling into it.

The leather creaked. \*Eeeee.\*

The sound of someone getting comfortable.

Erin stopped breathing.

She blinked.



\*It's a trick of the light. It's the shadows. It's the memory of the leather foam decompressing.\*

But the depression remained. A perfect, invisible mold of a person.

And the smell got stronger.

The copper taste filled her mouth. It coated her tongue.

"Who's there?" Erin said.

Silence.

Then, the depression in the cushion shifted.

It began to rise.

Slowly. Deliberately.

As if the occupant was standing up to greet her.

Erin didn't wait to see what happened next.

She turned and ran.

She bolted back into the bedroom, slamming the door and locking it. She dragged the heavy oak dresser in front of the door, her nails scratching against the wood.

She backed away, clutching the lamp to her chest like a crucifix.

She stared at the door handle.

It didn't turn.

Nothing pounded on the wood.

Silence returned to the condo.

But it wasn't the silence of emptiness.

It was the silence of \*waiting\*.

Erin looked at the clock.

\*3:00.\*

She frowned. It had been 3:00 for... how long? Ten minutes?

She watched the numbers.

They didn't change.

The colon didn't blink.

Time had stopped.

Or maybe... maybe she wasn't in time anymore.

She grabbed her wrist, feeling for her pulse. It was racing. \*Thump-thump-thump.\*

She looked at her wristwatch, which she had left on the dresser. A Cartier Tank. Precise. Swiss.

The second hand was twitching.

Stuck.

Ticking back and forth on the 12.

\*Tick-tick. Tick-tick.\*

Erin slid down the wall, pulling her knees to her chest.

"You're tired," she whispered. "You're stressed. It's Van Hopper. It's the guilt."

She said the word aloud, testing it.

\*Guilt.\*

Did she feel guilt?

She saved a murderer. She knew he was a murderer.

Was this... punishment?

No. She was a lawyer. She didn't believe in karma. She believed in evidence.

And there was no evidence here. Just a smell. Just a shadow.

Just a stopped clock.

She closed her eyes.

\*Wake up. Wake up.\*

When she opened them again, the clock blinked.

\*3:01.\*

The spell broke.

The air lightened. The smell faded, replaced by the scent of her own lavender laundry detergent.

Erin let out a breath she felt she had been holding for an hour.

She stood up, her legs shaky.

She moved the dresser back. She unlocked the door.

She looked into the hallway.

Empty.

Jasper trotted in, meowing, rubbing against her leg as if nothing had happened.

Erin picked him up, burying her face in his fur. He smelled like cat food and dust.

Real smells.

"You're okay," she whispered. "We're okay."

She walked to the living room.

The chair was empty. The cushion was smooth.

She walked to the window, looking out at the city.

It was raining now. A light drizzle slicking the glass.

She pressed her hand against the cool pane.

It was just a nightmare. A waking dream.

But as she turned to go back to bed, she saw it.

On the coffee table.

Her notebook.

She had left it closed. She was sure of it.

Now, it was open.

And on the blank page, there was a drawing.

A crude, charcoal sketch.

Not charcoal.

Soot.

It was a picture of a face. screaming. The mouth was too wide. The eyes were black holes.

And under it, three words written in a jagged, violent hand.

\*WE ARE HERE.\*

Erin stared at it.

She touched the soot. It came away black on her finger.

She hadn't drawn it.

She lived alone.

She looked back at the empty chair.

And for the first time in her life, Erin Bruner was afraid to close her eyes.

She walked to the kitchen and turned on every light.

She sat at the island, staring at the soot on her finger, waiting for the sun to rise.

But the night was long.

And the city outside felt like a cage.

## CHAPTER 2: ARRAIGNMENT

The morning after the Van Hopper verdict, the sun didn't rise so much as the grey sky just got slightly brighter. It was a Chicago morning—relentless, industrial, and cold.

Erin drove to the office on autopilot. Her hands gripped the leather steering wheel of her Mercedes SL, her knuckles white. She had scrubbed the soot off her finger, using a pumice stone until the skin was raw, but she could still feel it. A phantom stain. A brand.

She had burned the notebook page in the sink. Watched the face scream as it turned to ash.

\*Stress,\* she repeated, like a mantra. \*Just stress. Hallucination caused by sleep deprivation.\*

The firm was buzzing. The "Victory Lap" had turned into a "Victory March."

Paralegals smiled at her. Junior associates got out of her way.

Ray, her second chair on the Van Hopper case, was waiting by her office door. He looked fresh, rested. He probably slept like a baby.

"Boss," he said, grinning. "The press is calling. CNN wants a statement. The Times wants an interview. \*Dateline\* is asking for exclusivity."

"Tell them no comment," Erin said, unlocking her door.

Ray blinked. "No comment? Erin, you're the 'Giant Killer.' You should be taking a lap. This is free publicity."

"I'm taking a coffee, Ray. And aspirin. And silence."

She went into her office and shut the door.

She leaned against it, closing her eyes.

The silence of the office was usually a comfort. Today, it felt oppressive. The air was too filtered. The light was too artificial.

She walked to her desk.

There was a file on it.

A red folder. \*Urgent.\*

A sticky note from Karl: \*See me. Now.\*

Erin dropped her bag and walked to the corner office.

Karl was on the phone, looking out at the city. He waved her in.

"I know," he was saying. "I know it's a disaster. We'll contain it."

He hung up.

He turned to Erin. He looked serious. Not the shark-smile serious. Real serious.

"Sit down."

Erin sat. "Who's the disaster?"

"The Archdiocese."

"The priest case?"

"Father Richard Moore. He was arraigned this morning. The judge denied bail."

"Denied bail? On a negligent homicide? That's aggressive. Usually, they bond out on ROR."

"The judge is Brewster. He's up for re-election. He wants to look tough on... weirdness."

"Weirdness?"

"The DA... Ethan Thomas... he made a show of it. Called Moore a 'flight risk to the spiritual plane' or some nonsense. But it worked. Moore is in County. Solitary."

Karl slid the file across the desk.

"I need you to go down there. Now."

"To the jail?"

"To take the case."

Erin hesitated. "Karl, I just finished a six-month murder trial. I need a break. I need... sleep."

"You need the Senior Partnership," Karl said softly. "And this is the price of admission."

He pointed to the file.

"If you win this... if you save the Church from a hundred-million-dollar liability suit... you can write your own ticket. You can have my job when I retire. You can have the world."

"And if I lose?"

"Don't lose."

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The drive to the County Jail was a descent into the underworld.

Erin turned off the highway, leaving the gleaming glass canyons of the Loop behind. The scenery changed instantly. Broken sidewalks. Boarded-up storefronts. Liquor stores with bars on the windows.

It was Dante's circles, manifest in brick and mortar.

The jail itself was a fortress. A brutalist block of concrete surrounded by razor wire.

Erin hated it.

She hated the smell—bleach and body odor. She hated the metal detectors. She hated the way the guards looked at her legs, eyes dead and hungry.

She checked in at the front desk.

"Attorney visit for Moore," she said.

The guard, a heavy-set woman named Officer Higgins, looked up. She was chewing gum with a slow, bovine rhythm.

"The Exorcist guy?"

"Father Moore."

"Yeah. He's in D Block. Watch yourself, honey. He's spooky."

"Spooky how?"

"Just... stares. And the other inmates? They don't like him. They scream when he walks by."

Erin walked down the long corridor to D Block.

The air got colder as she went deeper into the facility.

She passed the communal cells. Usually, the inmates catcalled her. \*Hey baby. Nice legs. Come here.\*

Today, they were silent.

They watched her pass with dark, hooded eyes.

Some of them made signs. Hand gestures. Warding off evil? Or inviting it?

Erin kept her eyes forward. \*Click-clack. Click-clack.\* The sound of her heels echoed like gunshots in a crypt.

She reached the interview room.

The guard unlocked the heavy steel door. \*Clang.\*

"He's in there. Good luck."

Erin stepped inside.

The room was small, windowless. A metal table bolted to the floor. Two chairs.

Father Richard Moore sat in the far chair.

He was wearing his clerical collar, but his shirt was wrinkled. He looked thin. Gaunt.

But it was his stillness that struck her.

He wasn't fidgeting. He wasn't pacing. He sat with his hands folded on the table, perfectly motionless. Like a statue carved from grey stone.

He didn't look up when she entered.

"Father Moore?"

He slowly raised his head.

His eyes.

Erin had seen a lot of eyes. Killers, liars, victims. Dead eyes. Crazy eyes.

Moore's eyes were different.

They were deep. Infinite. And terrified.

Not terrified of her. Terrified of what he had seen. Terrified of what he knew.

"I'm Erin Bruner," she said, setting her briefcase down. "I'm your attorney."

Moore looked at the briefcase. Then at her.

"You're the one," he said. His voice was rough, unused.

"The one?"

"The one they sent."

"The Archdiocese sent me. Yes."

"Not the Archdiocese," Moore whispered.

He leaned forward. The chains on his wrists rattled. \*Chink-chink.\*

"Do you believe in the Devil, Ms. Bruner?"

Erin paused. It was the standard question. Every religious nut she defended asked it.

"I believe in the Constitution, Father. And I believe in the Rules of Evidence."

Moore smiled. It was a sad, broken smile.

"That's a pity," he said. "Because the Devil believes in you."

Erin felt a chill run down her spine. The same copper taste filled her mouth. The taste from 3:00 AM.

"Let's focus on the case," she said, opening her notebook. "Ethan Thomas is charging you with negligent homicide. He says you told Emily Rose to stop her medication."

"I told her to trust God."

"In the eyes of the law, that's the same thing as negligence."

"Then the law is blind."

"The law is a tool, Father. And right now, it's a tool being used to crush you. I can stop that. But you have to work with me. You have to tell me exactly what happened in that barn."

Moore looked away. He looked at the two-way mirror. He seemed to be looking through it, seeing something on the other side.

"The barn," he whispered.

"Yes. The night she died."



"She didn't die," Moore said. "She was released."

"Father..."

"You want to know what happened?" Moore looked back at her. His intensity was physically palpable, like heat radiating from a furnace. "We opened a door. And something came through. Something that had been waiting a long time."

"Something?"

"We are Legion," Moore quoted. "For we are many."

Erin wrote it down. \*Client delusional? Religious fixation.\*

But her hand shook. The pen wavered on the page.

"We'll enter a plea of Not Guilty," she said. "We'll argue... alternative causality."

"You can argue whatever you want," Moore said. "But be warned, Erin Bruner."

"Warned of what?"

Moore reached out. He touched her hand.

His skin was ice cold.

"Once you look at the darkness," he whispered. "The darkness looks back. It knows your name now."

Erin pulled her hand away.

"I'm a lawyer, Father. I deal in facts."

"Then here is a fact," Moore said. "It's 3:00 AM. Do you know why you wake up at 3:00 AM?"

Erin froze.

How did he know?

"It's the mocking of the Trinity," Moore said softly. "The inverse of 3:00 PM. The miracle hour. The hour of death. The hour when the veil is thinnest."

Erin stood up. She packed her bag. She needed to get out of there. The air in the room was suffocating. It smelled of sulfur and fear.

"I'll... I'll see you at the bail hearing."

She knocked on the door. "Guard!"

As the door opened, she looked back.

Moore was back in his statue pose. Staring at his hands.

"Pray," he whispered. "Pray for protection."

Erin walked out into the corridor.

She walked fast.

She didn't look at the inmates.

She got to the lobby and burst out into the rain.

She took a deep breath of the wet, smoggy air.

\*He's crazy,\* she told herself. \*He's just a crazy priest.\*

But she looked at her watch.

The second hand was moving.

\*Tick-tick.\*

She got in her car.

She looked in the rearview mirror.

Her eyes looked tired. Scared.

"Get a grip," she said aloud.

But she knew.

The game had changed.

This wasn't Van Hopper. This wasn't a murder trial.

This was something else.

And she was already in deep water.

## CHAPTER 3: JURY

Jury selection was a blood sport.

Erin Bruner stood at the podium, her eyes scanning the pool of forty strangers sitting on the wooden benches. They looked bored, annoyed, or terrified.

To Erin, they weren't people. They were variables.

She needed twelve variables that added up to "Acquittal."

"Mr. Henderson," Erin said, looking at a man in the second row. He was wearing a plaid shirt and looked like he worked with his hands. "You stated on your questionnaire that you attend church 'occasionally'. Can you define 'occasionally'?"

Henderson shifted in his seat. "Christmas and Easter. Maybe a wedding."

"Do you believe in the Devil, Mr. Henderson?"

The courtroom went silent. It was the question. The pivot point.

Henderson laughed nervously. "I believe in... bad people."

"But a literal Devil? Horns, tail, pitchfork?"

"No. That's fairy tales."

Erin marked a check next to his name. \*Skeptic. Good.\*

She moved to the next candidate. Mrs. Gable.

Mrs. Gable was wearing a high-necked blouse and clutching a purse that Erin suspected contained a Bible.

"Mrs. Gable," Erin said softly. "Same question."

"I believe the Bible is the literal word of God," Mrs. Gable said. Her voice was steel.

"And the Bible speaks of demons. Of possession."

"It does."

"If the evidence suggests that Emily Rose was suffering from a medical condition... would your faith prevent you from accepting that?"

Mrs. Gable hesitated. Just for a second.

"God created medicine, Ms. Bruner. But He also created the soul."

Erin marked an X. \*Strike. Too unpredictable. If she thinks Moore is a holy man, she might acquit. But if she thinks he failed a holy rite, she might hang him.\*

Erin walked back to the table. Karl leaned in.

"What about Number 8?" he whispered.

Erin looked at Juror 8. A young man. Graduate student vibes. Glasses. He was reading a book while he waited. \*The Stranger\* by Camus.

"He's an intellectual," Erin whispered back. "He'll hate the exorcism stuff. But he'll hate the State telling people what to believe even more."

"Risky."

"I like risky. Keep him."

Then she saw Juror 11.

A middle-aged woman. Nurse's uniform. She looked tired.

But it wasn't her job that caught Erin's eye.

It was her wrist.

She was wearing a medical alert bracelet. Epilepsy? Diabetes?

And in her other hand, hidden under a folded newspaper... a rosary.

Cheap plastic beads. The kind you get in a hospital chapel.

She was rubbing the beads. \*Rub. Rub. Rub.\*

Anxious.

Erin studied her.

\*Medical background + Secret Faith + Anxiety.\*

This was the Wild Card.

If Moore was negligent, a nurse would crucify him.

But if Emily was suffering... if the medicine failed... a nurse would understand that failure better than anyone.

"Ms. Bruner?" Judge Brewster asked. "The defense has one strike remaining."

Erin looked at Mrs. Gable (The Fundamentalist) and Juror 11 (The Nurse).

She had to cut one.

Mrs. Gable was safe. She would respect the priest.

Juror 11 was dangerous. She knew the science.

Erin looked at Moore.

He was watching Juror 11 too.

"Keep her," Moore whispered.

"The nurse? She'll tear apart the medical negligence defense."

"She knows pain," Moore said. "Look at her eyes."

Erin looked.

Juror 11 wasn't just tired. She was grieving. It was a subtle look—the hollow set of the jaw.

Erin took a breath.

"The defense thanks and excuses... Mrs. Gable."

Karl kicked her under the table.

"You're gambling," he hissed.

"It's a casino, Karl," Erin said, sitting down. "House always wins unless you cheat."

## CHAPTER 4: THE PEOPLE

Ethan Thomas did not gamble. He calculated.

He sat in his office, the blinds drawn against the afternoon sun. The air smelled of old paper and peppermint tea.

He was reviewing his opening statement.

He had annotated it in red ink.

\*Focus on the body. The girl. The victim.\*

He picked up the photo of Emily Rose. The "After" photo.

It made him angry.

Not a flash of anger, but a deep, simmering burn.

He was a man of faith. He taught Sunday School. He believed in the Resurrection.

But this... this wasn't faith. This was medieval barbarism masquerading as piety.

He looked at the toxicology report.

\*Blood levels of Gambrolic acid: Zero.\*

She hadn't taken her medication in two months.

Because Moore told her not to.

Because Moore told her the pills were blocking the "spiritual connection."

"Idolatry," Ethan whispered.

It was the sin of pride. Moore thought he knew better than the doctors God had put on this earth. Moore thought he could wrestle the Devil with a prayer book.

And because of his pride, a nineteen-year-old girl had starved to death in a puddle of her own urine.

Ethan stood up. He was a big man, broad-shouldered. He walked to the window.

He looked out at the courthouse.

He knew Erin Bruner's reputation. The "Giant Killer." The woman who let Van Hopper walk.

She was smart. She was cynical. She would try to turn this into a circus. She would try to put God on trial.

Ethan wouldn't let her.

He would keep it small. He would keep it grounded.

\*Condition. Diagnosis. Negligence. Death.\*

A simple chain of cause and effect.

He checked his watch.

3:00 PM.

He frowned.

He felt... something.

A pressure in the room.

He turned around.

His office was empty.

But the air felt heavy.

And on his desk, the photo of Emily Rose had shifted.

It was face down.

He had left it face up.

He walked to the desk. He flipped the photo over.

Emily's black eyes stared up at him.

"You can't scare me," Ethan said to the empty room. "I am on the side of the Righteous."

He put the photo in his briefcase.

He snapped the locks shut. \*Click. Click.\*

He grabbed his coat.

He wasn't afraid of demons.

He was afraid of men who thought they could control them.

## CHAPTER 5: OPENING

The courtroom was packed. Every seat in the gallery was filled. Reporters, curious locals, theology students, goth kids hoping for a show. It was a circus.

Judge Brewster banged his gavel.

"All rise."

The bailiff called the court to order.

Erin stood. She smoothed her skirt. She checked her notes one last time.

\*Reasonable Doubt. Institutional Failure. Human Limits.\*

"Mr. Thomas," Judge Brewster said. "Your opening."

Ethan Thomas walked to the jury box. He looked like a statue of Justice come to life. Solid. Dependable.

"Ladies and gentlemen," he began. His voice was a deep baritone that filled the room without shouting. "This is a simple case. It is a tragic case, but it is simple."

He held up a bottle of pills.

"This is Gambrolic. It is a medication used to treat epilepsy and psychosis. It controls seizures. It calms the mind."

He set the bottle down on the railing. \*Clack.\*

"Emily Rose had a medical condition. A serious, treatable condition. She went to doctors. She got a prescription. She was getting better."

He walked to the defense table and pointed a finger at Father Moore.

"Then she met this man."

The jury looked at Moore. Moore stared straight ahead.

"Father Richard Moore told her to stop taking the pills. He told her that her seizures were not a disease, but a gift. A curse. A possession."

Thomas paused.

"He told a sick girl to stop eating. He tied her to a bed. He watched her waste away until she weighed sixty-eight pounds. And when she died... he prayed."

Thomas looked at the jury, his eyes burning with righteous anger.

"We cannot allow superstition to override the law. We cannot allow negligence to masquerade as faith. We ask you to find the defendant guilty of negligent homicide."

Thomas sat down.

The jury looked shaken. It was a powerful narrative.

Erin stood up.

She didn't walk to the jury box. She walked to the witness stand. She touched the wood of the chair.

"Facts," she said. Her voice was cool, clear water. "Mr. Thomas has given you facts. Emily was sick. She stopped her meds. She died."

She turned to the jury.

"But facts are like bricks. You can build a wall with them. Or you can build a bridge. Mr. Thomas is building a wall. He wants to wall off the things we don't understand. He wants to tell you that everything in this world can be explained by a pill."

She walked to the center of the room.

"But we all know... in the quiet of the night... that isn't true."

She saw Juror 11 (The Nurse) nod slightly.

"We will show you that Emily Rose was not a victim of negligence. She was a victim of something science could not name. Something medicine could not cure. Father Moore didn't tell her to stop eating. \*Something else\* stopped her."



She looked at Moore.

"We will ask you to open your minds. To look past the wall of facts. To see the possibility... that Father Moore was the only one who truly tried to save her."

## CHAPTER 6: EXHIBIT A - THE PHOTOGRAPH

**\*\*[INTERSTITIAL DOCUMENT]\*\***

**\*\*STATE'S EXHIBIT A\*\***

**\*\*Subject:\*\*** Emily Rose

**\*\*Date:\*\*** November 1, 1976

**\*\*Location:\*\*** Rose Farmhouse, Bedroom 2 (The Barn)

**\*\*Photographer:\*\*** Det. J. Miller

**\*\*Visual Description:\*\***

Subject is female, age 19. Body is in a supine position on a military-style cot.

Rigor mortis is fully established.

Subject is severely emaciated. Rib cage is prominently visible through the skin. Hip bones protrude sharply.

**\*\*Injuries:\*\***

1. Severe lacerations to the face and lips (consistent with self-inflicted biting).
2. Bruising on wrists and ankles (consistent with leather restraints).
3. **\*\*Knees:\*\*** The patellar tendons appear ruptured. The knees are swollen to twice their normal size, bruised purple and black. (Consistent with prolonged kneeling on hard surfaces).
4. **\*\*Eyes:\*\*** Open. Subconjunctival hemorrhage (broken blood vessels) in both eyes. The sclera is completely red.

**\*\*Handwritten Note in Margin (Erin Bruner's Handwriting):\*\***

\*Look at the hands. Not the bruises. The position. Palms up. Open. Accepting.\*

\*This isn't a victim. This is a martyr.\*

\*Stories begin lying the moment you take a picture.\*

## CHAPTER 7: EMILY BEFORE

\*Flashback. September 1976.\*

The kitchen of the Rose farmhouse smelled of yeast and cinnamon.

Emily Rose was kneading dough. Her hands were strong, dusted with flour. She worked the dough rhythmically. \*Push, turn, fold. Push, turn, fold.\*

It was muscle memory. Like the Rosary. Like the seasons.

"You're going to miss this," her mother said, watching her from the sink.

"I can buy bread at the store, Mama," Emily said, smiling.

"Store bread tastes like cardboard. You need good food if you're going to be studying all night."

Emily laughed. It was a bright, clear sound. She wiped a stray hair from her forehead, leaving a streak of flour.

She looked out the window. The fields were turning gold. The harvest was coming.

But she wouldn't be here for it.

She was going to the University. To the city.

It felt like a betrayal. And a liberation.

She walked to the little shrine in the hallway. A statue of the Virgin Mary, cheap plaster painted blue and white.

She knelt.

"Hail Mary, full of grace..."

She didn't pray for success. She didn't pray for money.

She prayed for protection.

Because lately...

She stopped.

She looked at the statue.

The painted eyes of the Virgin seemed to be looking past her.

Looking at the shadows in the corner of the hall.

Emily turned.

Nothing. Just the coat rack.

But for a second, the coat rack had looked like a tall, thin man wearing a hat.

Emily shivered.

"Just nerves," she whispered.

She finished her prayer.

But when she stood up, her knees popped. A sharp, dry crack.

She winced.

She didn't know it yet, but that sound—the sound of her own body breaking—would be the soundtrack of her life for the next two months.

## CHAPTER 8: CAMPUS

The University was loud.

That was Emily's first impression. It was a constant wall of noise. Cars, music, shouting, construction.

She loved it.

It drowned out the quiet of the farm. It drowned out the feeling of being watched.

Her roommate was a girl named Alice. Alice had short hair, wore oversized sweaters, and smoked clove cigarettes.

"You're a virgin, right?" Alice asked within five minutes of meeting her.

Emily blushed. "Is it that obvious?"

"You have a crucifix on your wall and you fold your underwear. It's adorable."

Alice blew smoke out the window. "Don't worry. We'll corrupt you by Thanksgiving."

Emily laughed.

She went to classes. Philosophy 101. Literature.

She sat in the front row. She took notes.

She walked through the quad in the autumn sunlight, kicking leaves.

She felt... normal.

For the first time in years.

It was a Tuesday night when it changed.

Emily was walking back from the library. It was late. The fog had rolled in off the lake, thick and cold.

She was taking the shortcut through the park.

She heard footsteps behind her.

\*Crunch. Crunch.\*

She stopped.

The footsteps stopped.

"Hello?"

Silence.

She walked faster.

\*Crunch. Crunch.\*

She started to run.

She burst out of the park and onto the lit street.

She looked back.

The fog swirled.

There was no one there.

But in the mist... she saw a shape.

A dark, towering shape. Not a man. Too tall. Too thin.

It raised a hand. A long, claw-like hand.

And waved.

Emily turned and ran to her dorm.

She locked the door. She pushed her desk in front of it.

"Whoa, killer," Alice said, looking up from her book. "What's wrong?"

"Nothing," Emily gasped. "Just... a creep in the park."

Alice rolled her eyes. "City life. Get some pepper spray."

Emily nodded.

But she knew pepper spray wouldn't help.

Because the thing in the park didn't have eyes.

It had empty sockets filled with black fire.

And it knew where she lived.

## CHAPTER 9: FIRST NIGHT

\*November 1976.\*

The first time it fully took her, it wasn't a monster. It was a smell.

Emily was asleep in her dorm room. Alice was gone for the weekend.

Emily woke up choking.

The air in the room was thick with smoke.

"Fire," she thought.

She sat up.

But there was no orange glow. No alarm.

Just the smell.

Burning hair. Burning rubber. And... meat. Seared meat.

She coughed, swinging her legs out of bed.

The floor was cold.

She walked to the window.

The smell was coming from \*inside\* the room.

Then the weight hit her.

It wasn't a gradual pressure. It was instant. Like the gravity in the room had suddenly increased tenfold.

She fell to her knees.

\*Crack.\*

The pain was blinding. Her kneecaps slammed into the hardwood floor.

She tried to stand.

She couldn't.

Her legs were locked.

Not cramped. Locked. Rigid as iron bars.

"Help," she whispered.

But her voice was gone. Her throat was clamped shut.

She looked at the clock.

\*3:00 AM.\*

The numbers burned red.

Then, the door to her closet slowly creaked open.

\*Eeeeeeee.\*

It was dark inside.

But something was moving in the clothes.

Shifting.

Rustling.

A face appeared in the darkness.

It wasn't a face. It was a mask of melting wax.

It smiled.

And then the voice spoke. Not from the closet. From inside her own head.

\*"Emily..."\*

It sounded like her father. But wrong. Twisted.

\*"Emily... why did you leave us?"\*

The pressure increased. She was being crushed. Her ribs groaned.

She closed her eyes and prayed.

"Hail Mary... Hail Mary..."

\*"She can't hear you,"\* the voice laughed. \*"She is in Heaven. You are in the pit."\*

## CHAPTER 10: ERIN INVESTIGATES

The Rose farm was a grey smudge on the horizon of the flat Midwest landscape.

Erin parked her rental car at the end of the long dirt driveway.

It was raining. Of course.

She put on her trench coat and walked to the porch.

The house looked abandoned. Paint peeling. Roof sagging.

But there was smoke coming from the chimney.

She knocked.

Maria Rose opened the door.

Emily's mother was a small woman, worn down by grief like a stone in a river. But her eyes were clear.

"Ms. Bruner," she said. "Father Moore said you would come."

The kitchen was warm. It smelled of yeast.

"Coffee?" Maria asked.

"Please."

Erin sat at the table. It was scratched, scarred.

"Mrs. Rose, I need to ask you about Emily's childhood. Was there any history of mental illness? Depression? Mood swings?"

Maria poured the coffee. Her hand was steady.

"Emily was happy," she said. "She was full of light. Until she went to that school."

"The University?"

"The city. The godless place."

"Mrs. Rose... the medical report says Emily had Temporal Lobe Epilepsy. It causes hallucinations. Hearing voices."

Maria sat down. She looked at Erin with pity.

"You think it was a sickness."

"I think it's a medical explanation."

"Can medicine make a girl speak in languages she never learned? Can medicine make a girl know things she couldn't know?"

"What things?"

"She knew about my sin," Maria whispered. "She looked at me... with those black eyes... and she told me things I had only told the priest in confession twenty years ago."

Erin paused. "Suggestion. Cold reading. Psychics do it all the time."

"It wasn't a trick, Ms. Bruner. It was... knowledge. Dark knowledge."

Maria stood up.

"Come with me. I want to show you something."

She led Erin to the barn.

It was cold inside. The wind whistled through the gaps in the wood.

"This is where she died," Maria said.

Erin looked at the cot in the center of the room. It was still there.

And on the floor...

Scratches.

Deep gouges in the wood.

Erin knelt down.

They looked like claw marks.

"Did an animal do this?"



"Emily did this," Maria said. "With her fingernails. She dug into the wood to keep from... floating away."

"Floating?"

"Levitating, Ms. Bruner. They lifted her up. Like a doll."

Erin touched the wood.

She felt it again. The copper taste. The static.

She looked at the corner of the barn.

The shadows seemed to be moving. Coalescing.

"We should go," Erin said, standing up quickly.

"You feel it, don't you?" Maria asked.

"I feel the cold."

"You feel \*them\*," Maria said. "They are still here. They are waiting for the trial."

Erin walked out of the barn. fast.

She got in her car.

She drove away.

She didn't look back.

But she checked the rearview mirror.

And for a second... just a second... she saw a face in the back seat.

Smiling.

She blinked. It was gone.

She gripped the wheel.

"Psychosis," she whispered. "It's contagious."

But she locked the doors.